GOOD LORD!

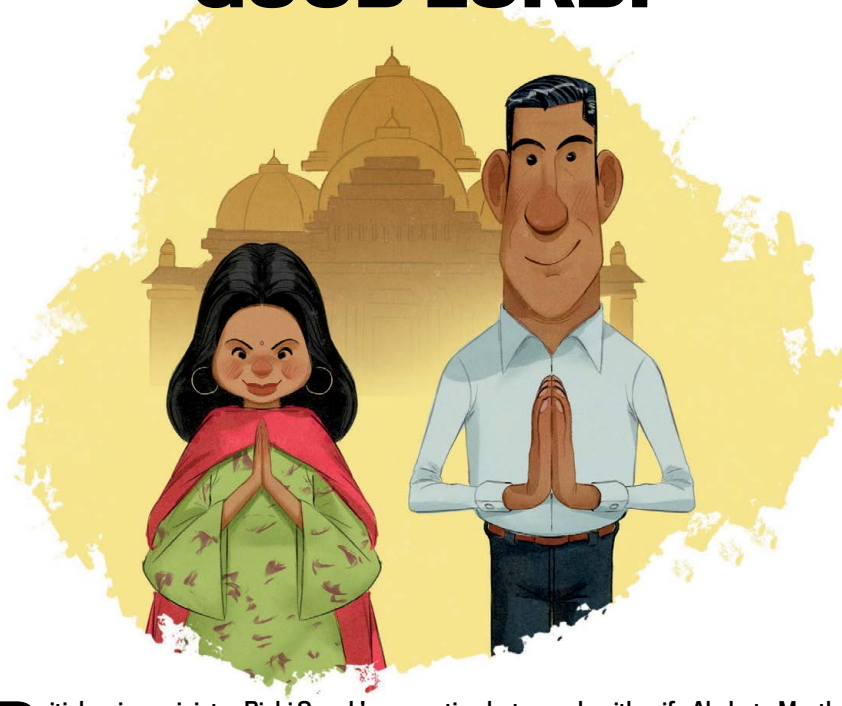


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

British prime minister Rishi Sunak's romantic photograph with wife Akshata Murthy notwithstanding, the couple's visit to the Swaminarayan Akshardham temple in Delhi led to a furore in Gujarat. Reason: the couple chose to pay obeisance to Swaminarayan, a 19th-century ascetic believed by his followers to be a manifestation of Krishna, instead of Hindu deities worshipped for centuries. The sect is already in a face-off with other Sanatana Dharma sages, who had earlier protested against a plaque installed at a temple in Gujarat's Botad, which showed Hanuman bowing down to Swaminarayan. The plaque was removed, but the duel continues.

UPFRONT



A Close Watch

Senior Karnataka Congress leader **B.K. Hariprasad** was slapped with a show-cause notice by the party's disciplinary panel as he took another dig at Chief Minister Siddaramaiah, his second such outburst in as many months after being left out of the state cabinet. "Wearing a Hublot watch and a panche (dhoti) with khaki shorts inside doesn't make one a socialist," Hariprasad said at a public meeting, without naming anyone. But the Hublot wristwatch was an obvious reference to the controversial gift the CM declared as a state asset during his first term in 2016.

Reclaiming Her Constituency

The newly appointed Andhra Pradesh state BJP president **D. Purandeswari** has put paid to the plan of another party leader, Rajya Sabha member G.V.L. Narasimha Rao, who had set his eyes on the Visakhapatnam Lok Sabha seat, nurturing it for over two years. Then with the Congress, Purandeswari won the Visakhapatnam seat in 2009. After defecting to the BJP, she lost two successive elections from Rajampet (2014) and Visakhapatnam (2019), but now seems to have edged out Rao in the fight for the party ticket from her traditional seat.



ACT OF ATONEMENT?

Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) president **Lalu Yadav** and wife **Rabri Devi** flew to Deoghar in Jharkhand to offer prayers at the Baidyanath Dham on September 11, just a week after worshipping the Shivling at Harihar Nath Mandir in Bihar's Sonepur. While Lalu is a self-confessed Shiva *bhakt*, political circles in Patna are abuzz with speculations if the RJD boss is seeking penance or trying to neutralise the Bharatiya Janata Party's criticism after his video of cooking mutton with Congress leader Rahul Gandhi during the pious Hindu month of Shravan went viral.



TWITTER@LALUPRASADRJD

Son vs Son-in-law

The victory of Congress leader **Chandy Oommen**, son of the late Oommen Chandy, in the Puthuppally bypoll, has kicked off a debate over nepotism in Kerala politics. When Congress's rivals sought to highlight it as another case of 'son-rise', leader of Opposition V.D. Satheesan alleged that a son-in-law was emerging as a power centre in the Left Democratic Front regime too. The reference was to minister Mohammed Riyas—son-in-law of Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan.



Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Ajay Sukumaran, Amitabh Srivastava, Amarnath K. Menon and Jeemon Jacob